

Sequence-to-Sequence Models: Intro to Attention

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Why Do We Need Seq2Seq and Attention?

- ▶ Many real-world problems require transforming one sequence to another:
 - Translation: "Bonjour" $\rightarrow$ "Hello"
 - Dialogue systems: Question $\rightarrow$ Response
 - Speech: Audio $\rightarrow$ Text

Standard RNNs struggle with input/output sequences of different lengths and long-term dependencies.

Seq2Seq models + attention solve this with a powerful encoder-decoder framework.

By the end of this session, you should be able to:

- ▶ Explain the Seq2Seq architecture and encoder-decoder framework
- ▶ Contrast greedy decoding with beam search, and say why length normalization is needed
- ▶ Understand the bottleneck problem in fixed-size representations
- ▶ Describe the motivation for and core idea behind attention mechanisms
- ▶ Appreciate how attention improves performance in NLP tasks
- ▶ Score generated text with n-gram overlap metrics and state where they fail
- ▶ Recognize future directions in attention-based modeling

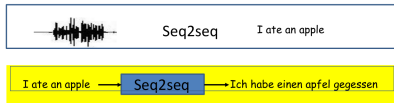
Seq2Seq Architecture

Key Idea: Map input sequence $\rightarrow$ intermediate vector $\rightarrow$ output sequence.

- ▶ **Encoder RNN:** Processes input sequence and compresses it into a **fixed-length vector** (context).
- ▶ **Decoder RNN:** Generates output sequence from the context vector.

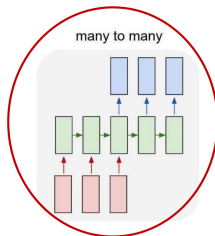
Applications:

- ▶ Machine translation
- ▶ Summarization
- ▶ Dialogue systems
- ▶ Speech recognition



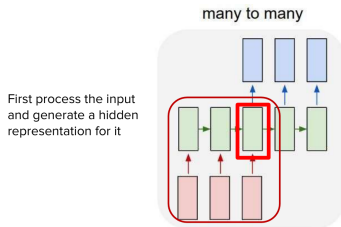
- Sequence goes in, sequence comes out
- No notion of “time synchrony” between input and output
 - May even not even maintain order of symbols
 - E.g. “I ate an apple” ↔ “Ich habe einen apfel gegessen”
 - Or even seem related to the input
 - E.g. “My screen is blank” ↔ “Please check if your computer is plugged in.”

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 2.



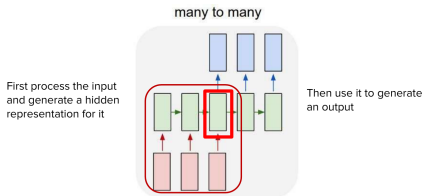
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 3 (RNN-taxonomy panel after A. Karpathy, 2015).

Delayed sequence to sequence



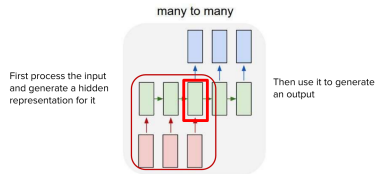
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 4 (RNN-taxonomy panel after A. Karpathy, 2015).

Delayed sequence to sequence



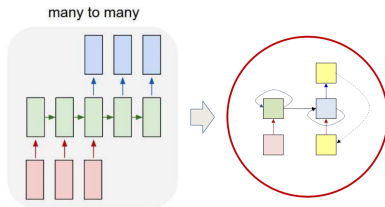
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 5 (RNN-taxonomy panel after A. Karpathy, 2015).

Delayed sequence to sequence



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 6 (RNN-taxonomy panel after A. Karpathy, 2015).

Problem: Each word that is output depends only on current hidden state, and not on previous outputs

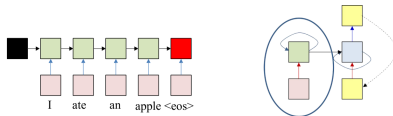


Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 7 (RNN-taxonomy panel after A. Karpathy, 2015).

► *Delayed* Sequence to sequence

- Delayed *self-referencing* sequence-to-sequence

The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 8.

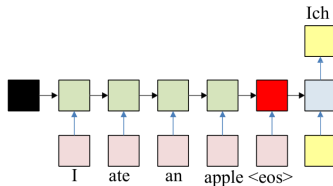
- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit <eos> symbol
 - The hidden activation at the <eos> “stores” all information about the sentence



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 9.

- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit <eos> symbol
 - The hidden activation at the <eos> “stores” all information about the sentence
- ▶ Subsequently a second RNN uses the hidden activation as initial state, and <sos> as initial symbol, to produce a sequence of outputs
 - The output at each time becomes the input at the next time
 - Output production continues until an <eos> is produced

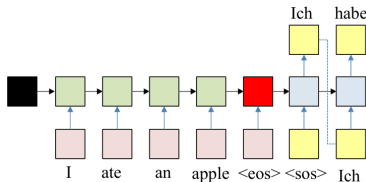
The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 10.

- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit `<eos>` symbol
 - The hidden activation at the `<eos>` “stores” all information about the sentence
- ▶ Subsequently a second RNN uses the hidden activation as initial state to produce a sequence of outputs
 - The output at each time becomes the input at the next time
 - Output production continues until an `<eos>` is produced

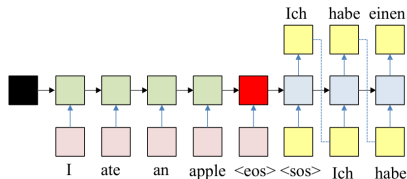
The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 11.

- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit <eos> symbol
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 - The output at each time becomes the input at the next time
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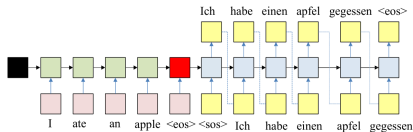
The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 12.

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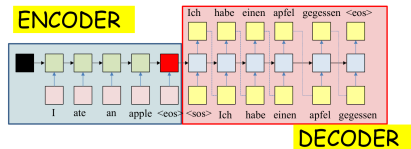
The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 13.

- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit <eos> symbol
 - The hidden activation at the <eos> “stores” all information about the sentence
- ▶ Subsequently a second RNN uses the hidden activation as initial state to produce a sequence of outputs
 - The output at each time becomes the input at the next time
 - Output production continues until an <eos> is produced

The “simple” translation model



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 14.

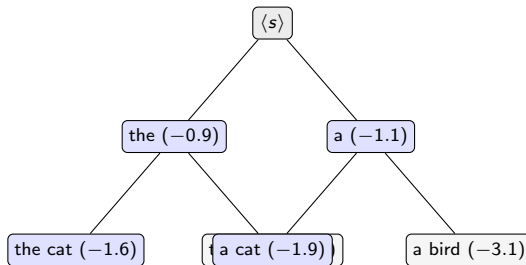
- ▶ The recurrent structure that extracts the hidden representation from the input sequence is the **encoder**
- ▶ The recurrent structure that utilizes this representation to produce the output sequence is the **decoder**

- ▶ At each step the decoder outputs a probability distribution over the vocabulary. Decoding is the search for the output sequence with the highest overall probability:

$$\hat{y} = \arg \max_y \prod_{t=1}^T P(y_t \mid y_{<t}, x)$$

- ▶ Searching over all possible sequences is intractable: $|V|^T$ candidates for vocabulary size $|V|$ and length T .
- ▶ **Greedy decoding:** take the single most probable token at every step.
- ▶ Greedy is cheap but short-sighted: a locally best word can commit the decoder to a worse overall sentence, and there is no way back.

- ▶ Keep the k best partial hypotheses (the **beam**) at each step instead of just one.
- ▶ At every step, extend each hypothesis with every vocabulary token, score all candidates by cumulative log-probability, and keep the top k .
- ▶ $k = 1$ recovers greedy decoding; machine translation typically uses beams of 4 to 10.



Beam of $k = 2$: at each step all extensions are scored and only the two best partial sequences (blue) survive.

- ▶ **Wider beams** cost more compute and give diminishing returns; very wide beams can even hurt quality by surfacing short, generic outputs.
- ▶ **Length bias:** summing log-probabilities makes every added token lower the score, so beam search favors short outputs.
- ▶ **Length normalization** divides the score by a length penalty so hypotheses of different lengths compete fairly. Wu et al. (2016) use $lp(Y) = ((5 + |Y|)/6)^\alpha$, with α tuned on held-out data ($\alpha = 0.2$ in that work).
- ▶ Beam search suits tasks with a well-defined target (translation, summarization). For open-ended generation it tends to produce repetitive, generic text, which is why sampling-based decoding is used there instead.

The Bottleneck Problem

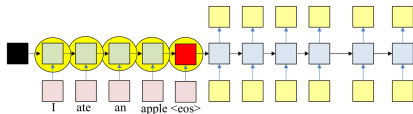
Fixed-length context vector = information bottleneck

- ▶ Encoder must **compress entire input sequence** into a single vector
- ▶ Longer or more complex inputs → information loss
- ▶ Decoder relies solely on that vector to produce outputs

Leads to poor performance on long sentences or tasks requiring high context awareness

- ▶ All the information about the input sequence is embedded into a single vector.
 - The “hidden” node layer at the end of the input sequence.
 - This one node is “overloaded” with information, particularly if the input is long.

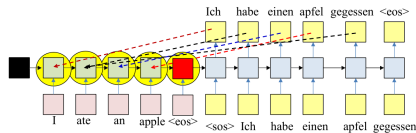
A problem with this framework



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 16.

- In reality: All hidden values carry information.
 - Some of which may be diluted by the time we get to the final state of the encoder.

A problem with this framework



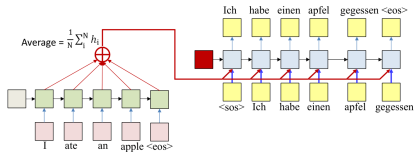
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 17.

- ▶ Every output is related to the input directly.
- ▶ Not sufficient to have the encoder hidden state to only the initial state of the decoder.
- ▶ Misses the direct relation of the outputs to the inputs.

Realization: We Need More Context!

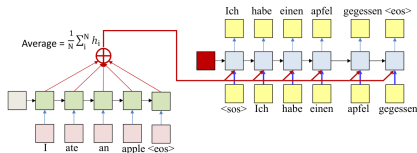
Decoder should have access to all encoder states, not just the final one.

- ▶ This inspired the development of the **attention mechanism**.
- ▶ Instead of passing only the final state, allow the decoder to “*look back*” at **all input positions**.



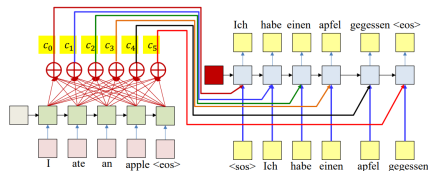
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 18.

- ▶ Simple solution: Compute the average of all encoder hidden states.
- ▶ Input this average to every stage of the decoder.
- ▶ The initial decoder hidden state is now separate from the encoder and may be a learnable parameter.



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 19.

- ▶ Problem: The average applies the same weight to every input.
- ▶ It supplies the same average to every output word.
- ▶ In practice, different outputs may be related to different inputs.
 - E.g., "Ich" is most related to "I", and "habe" and "gegessen" are both most related to "ate".

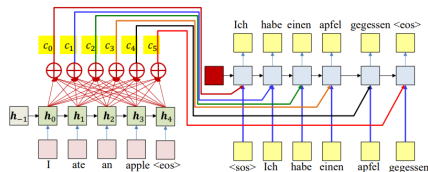


Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 20.

Solution: Use a *different* weighted average for each output word

- The weighted average provided for the t -th output word is:

$$c_t = \sum_i w_i(t) h_i$$



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$$c_t = \sum_{i=1}^N w_i(t) h_i$$

- ▶ This solution will work if the weights $w_i(t)$ can somehow be made to “focus” on the right input word
 - E.g., when predicting the word “apfel”, $w_3(3)$, the weight for “apple” must be high while the rest must be low
- ▶ How do we generate such weights??

Introduction to Attention Mechanism

Core Idea: Let the decoder **focus on different parts of the input** sequence at each step of decoding.

- ▶ At each decoding step, compute a **weighted sum** over all encoder hidden states.
- ▶ Weights reflect **relevance** of each input word to the current output word.

“Soft search” over inputs → more context-awareness.

1. Alignment Score:

$$e_{t,s} = \text{score}(h_{t-1}^{\text{dec}}, h_s^{\text{enc}})$$

2. Attention Weights (Softmax):

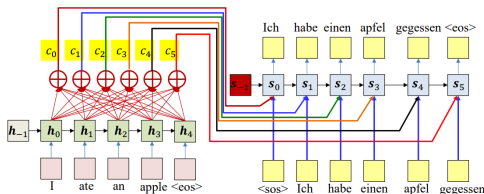
$$\alpha_{t,s} = \frac{\exp(e_{t,s})}{\sum_{s'} \exp(e_{t,s'})}$$

3. Context Vector:

$$c_t = \sum_s \alpha_{t,s} h_s^{\text{enc}}$$

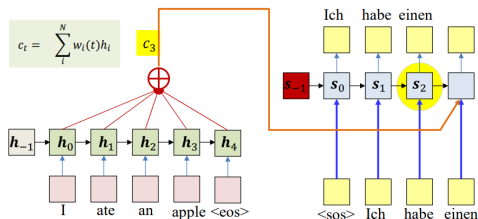
4. Decoder Step:

$$y_t = \text{Decoder}(y_{t-1}, h_{t-1}^{\text{dec}}, c_t)$$



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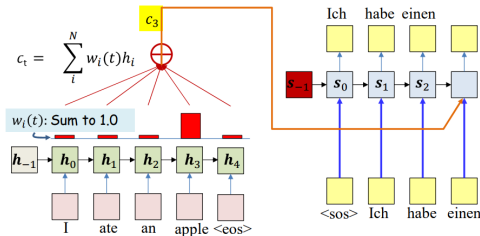
- **Attention weights:** The weights are dynamically computed as functions of decoder state.
- **Expectation:** if the model is well-trained, this will automatically “highlight” the correct input.
- But how are these computed?



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 29.

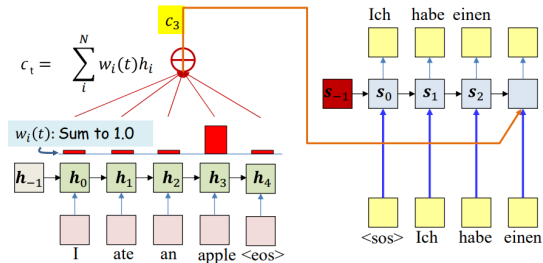
- ▶ The “attention” weights $w_i(t)$ must be computed from available information at time t .
- ▶ The primary information is s_{t-1} (the state at time $t - 1$).
- ▶ Also, the input word at time t , but generally not used for simplicity.

$$c_t = \sum_{i=1}^N w_i(t) h_i$$



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 30.

- ▶ The weights must be positive and sum to 1.0 (i.e., be a distribution).
- ▶ Ideally, they must be high for the inputs most relevant to the current output and low elsewhere.
- ▶ **Solution: A two step weight computation**
 - First compute raw weights (which could be +ve or -ve).
 - Then softmax them to convert them to a distribution.



- The weights $w_i(t)$ must be positive and sum to 1.0
 - I.e. be a distribution
 - Ideally, they must be high for the most relevant inputs for the i th output and low elsewhere
- Solution: A two step weight computation
 - First compute *raw* weights (which could be +ve or -ve)
 - Then softmax them to convert them to a distribution

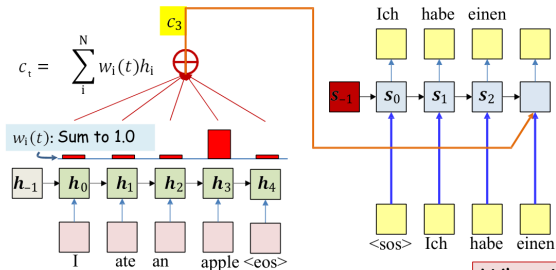
$$e_i(t) = g(h_i, s_{t-1})$$

$$w_i(t) = \frac{\exp(e_i(t))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(t))}$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 31.

1. The attention framework computes a different “context” vector at each output step?
2. The context vector is chosen as the hidden representation of the word with the highest weight?
3. The weight is a function of the encoder representation and the most recent decoder state?

1. The attention framework computes a different “context” vector at each output step? **True**
2. The context vector is chosen as the hidden representation of the word with the highest weight? **False**
3. The weight is a function of the encoder representation and the most recent decoder state? **True**



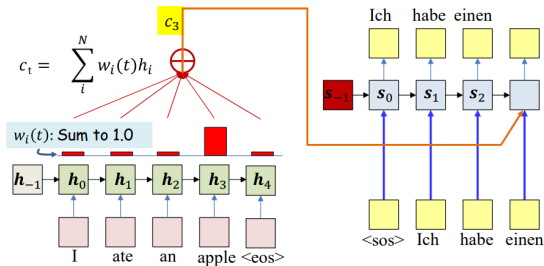
- The weights $w_i(t)$ must be positive and sum to 1.0
 - I.e. be a distribution
 - Ideally, they must be high for the most relevant inputs for the i th output and low elsewhere
- Solution: A two step weight computation
 - First compute *raw* weights (which could be +ve or -ve)
 - Then softmax them to convert them to a distribution

What is this function?

$$e_i(t) = g(h_i, s_{t-1})$$

$$w_i(t) = \frac{\exp(e_i(t))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(t))}$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 34.



- Typical options for $g()$ (**variables in red must be learned**)

$$g(h_i, s_{t-1}) = h_i^T s_{t-1}$$

$$g(h_i, s_{t-1}) = h_i^T \mathbf{W}_g s_{t-1}$$

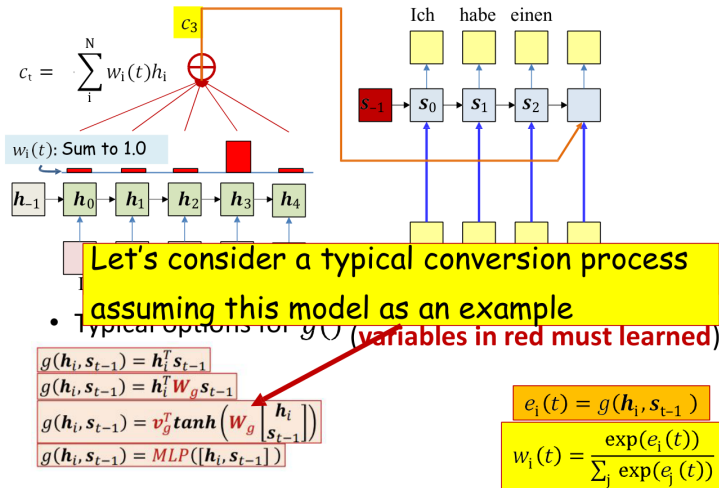
$$g(h_i, s_{t-1}) = \mathbf{v}_g^T \tanh\left(\mathbf{W}_g \begin{bmatrix} h_i \\ s_{t-1} \end{bmatrix}\right)$$

$$g(h_i, s_{t-1}) = \text{MLP}([h_i, s_{t-1}])$$

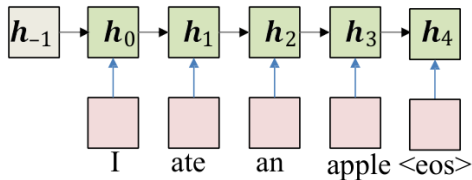
$$e_i(t) = g(h_i, s_{t-1})$$

$$w_i(t) = \frac{\exp(e_i(t))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(t))}$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 35.



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 36.



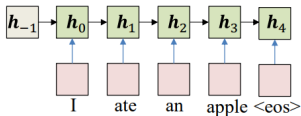
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 37.

Pass the input through the encoder to produce hidden representations h_i

s_{-1}

This may be

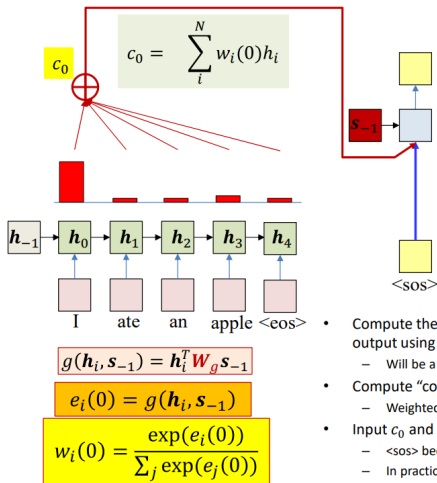
- a learned parameter, or
- Or just set to some fixed value, e.g. a vector of 1s or 0s, or
- Or the average of all the encoder embeddings: $\text{mean}(h_0, \dots, h_4)$
- Or $W_{init} \text{mean}(h_0, \dots, h_4)$ where W_{init} is a learned parameter



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 38.

Pass the input through the encoder to produce hidden representations h_i

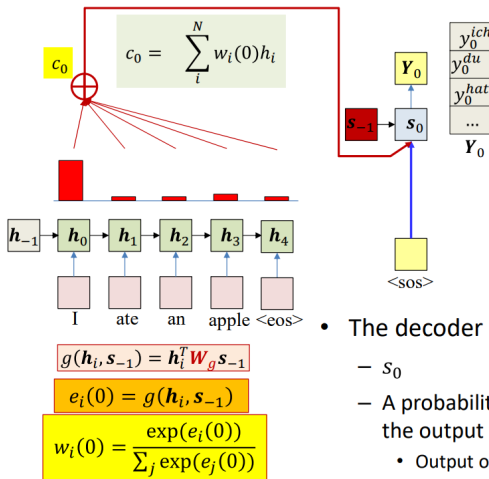
Converting an input: Inference



- Compute the attention weights $w_i(0)$ for the first output using s_{-1}
 - Will be a distribution over the input words
- Compute "context" c_0
 - Weighted sum of input word hidden states
- Input c_0 and <sos> to the decoder at time 0
 - <sos> because we are starting a new sequence
 - In practice we will enter the *embedding* of <sos>

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 39.

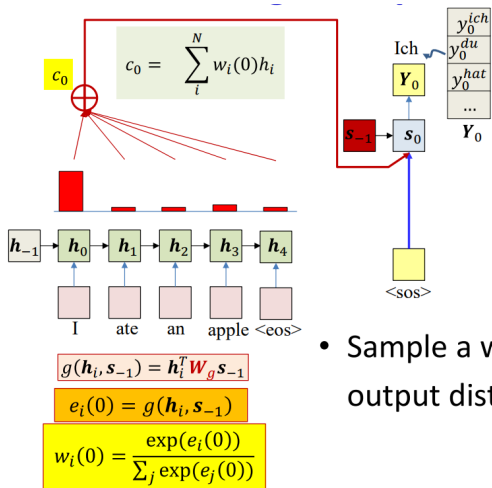
Converting an input: Inference



- The decoder computes
 - s_0
 - A probability distribution over the output vocabulary
 - Output of softmax output layer

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 40.

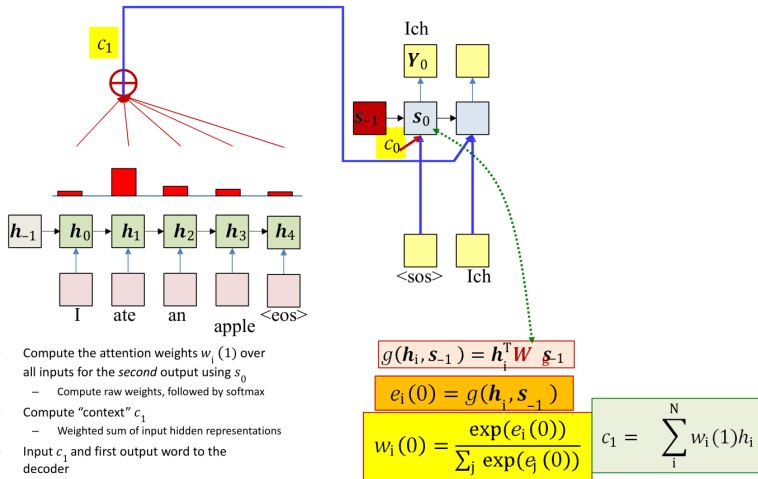
Converting an input: Inference



- Sample a word from the output distribution

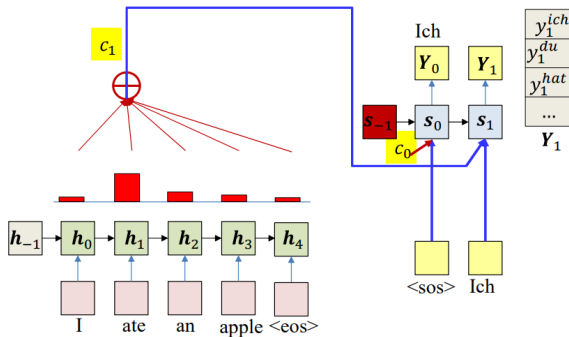
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 41.

Converting an input: Inference



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 42.

Converting an input: Inference



- The decoder computes
 - s_1
 - A probability distribution over the output vocabulary

$$g(h_i, s_0) = h_i^T W_g s_0$$

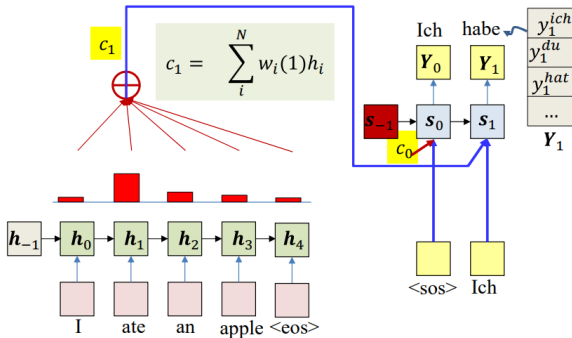
$$e_i(1) = g(h_i, s_0)$$

$$w_i(1) = \frac{\exp(e_i(1))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(1))}$$

$$c_1 = \sum_i^N w_i(1) h_i$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 43.

Converting an input: Inference



- Sample the second word from the output distribution

$$g(h_i, s_0) = h_i^T W_g s_0$$

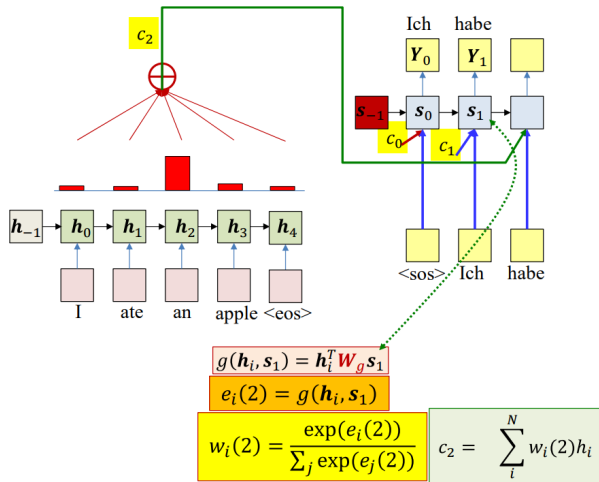
$$e_i(1) = g(h_i, s_0)$$

$$w_i(1) = \frac{\exp(e_i(1))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(1))}$$

$$c_1 = \sum_i^N w_i(1)h_i$$

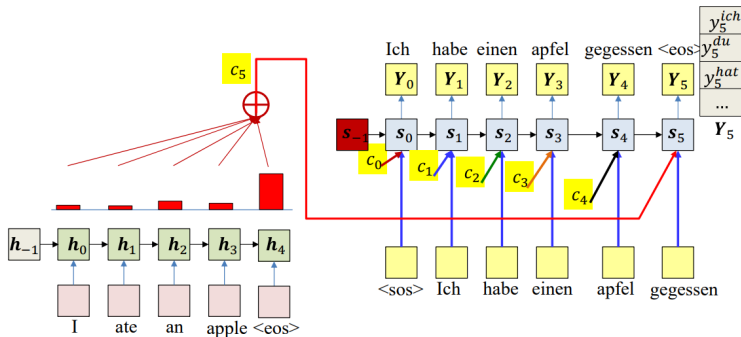
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 44.

Converting an input: Inference



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 45.

Converting an input: Inference



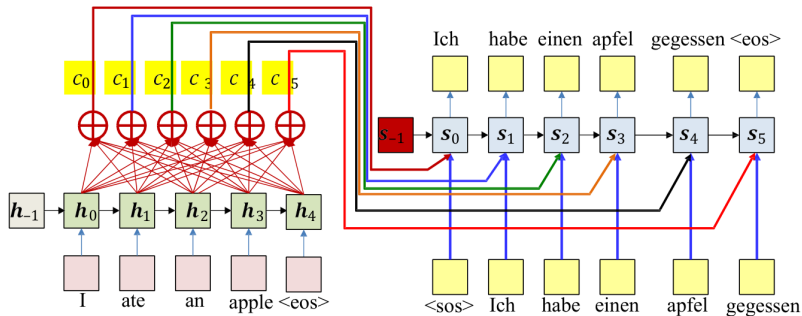
Continue this process until
<eos> is drawn

$$e_i(5) = g(h_i, s_4)$$

$$w_i(5) = \frac{\exp(e_i(5))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(5))}$$

$$c_5 = \sum_i^N w_i(5) h_i$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 56.

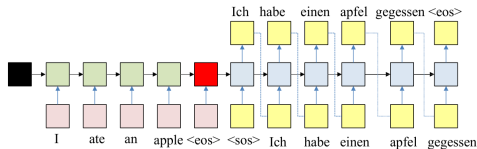


$$e_i(t) = g(h_i, s_{t-1})$$

$$w_i(t) = \frac{\exp(e_i(t))}{\sum_j \exp(e_j(t))}$$

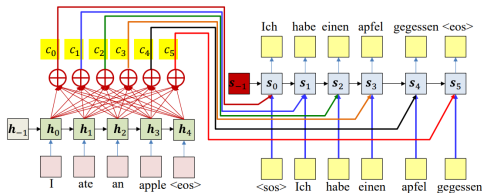
$$c_t = \sum_i^N w_i(t) h_i$$

Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 57.



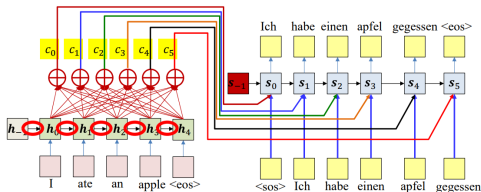
Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 98.

- ▶ The input sequence feeds into a recurrent structure
- ▶ The input sequence is terminated by an explicit `<eos>` symbol
 - The hidden activation at the `<eos>` "stores" all information about the sentence
- ▶ Subsequently a second RNN uses the hidden activation as initial state to produce a sequence of outputs



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 99.

- ▶ Encoder recurrently produces hidden representations of input word sequence
- ▶ Decoder recurrently generates output word sequence
 - For each output word the decoder uses a weighted average of the hidden input representations as input "context", along with the recurrent hidden state and the previous output word



Source: after CMU 11-785 (Spring 2024), Lecture 18: Sequence to Sequence Models & Attention, slide 100.

- **Problem:** Because of the recurrence, the hidden representation for any word is also influenced by *all* preceding words
 - The decoder is actually paying attention to the sequence, and not just the word

- ▶ Improves translation accuracy
- ▶ Helps handle **longer sequences**
- ▶ Interpretable: shows what the model is focusing on
- ▶ Forms the foundation of **Transformer models**

Led to development of:

- ▶ Bahdanau Attention (Additive, 2014)
- ▶ Luong Attention (Multiplicative, 2015)
- ▶ Self-Attention and Transformers (2017+)

Aspect	Basic Seq2Seq	With Attention
Memory	Single vector (fixed)	Multiple encoder states (dynamic)
Long Sequences	Poor performance	Good performance
Interpretability	Low	High (via attention weights)
Use Cases	Short/medium sequences	Longer, complex tasks

- ▶ Machine Translation
- ▶ Text Summarization
- ▶ Chatbots and Dialog Systems
- ▶ Speech Recognition
- ▶ Question Answering
- ▶ Video Captioning
- ▶ DNA Sequence Modeling

- ▶ BLEU is an n-gram overlap metric commonly used to evaluate text generation tasks such as machine translation. It compares generated text against reference text using precision of n-grams.
- ▶ Formula:

$$\text{BLEU} = \text{BP} \cdot \exp \left(\sum_{n=1}^N w_n \log p_n \right)$$

where:

- p_n = precision of n-grams
- w_n = weight for each n-gram order (usually uniform)
- BP = brevity penalty to penalize short hypotheses

► How it works:

- BLEU evaluates how many n-grams in the hypothesis match the reference.
- Missing or misordered words reduce the score.

► Example:

- Reference: "the cat is on the mat"
- Hypothesis: "the cat on mat"
- Unigram precision = $4/4 = 1.0$
- Bigram precision = $1/3 \approx 0.33$
- BLEU penalizes missing words via BP.

► Why it matters:

- Easy to compute and widely adopted for automatic evaluation of generated text.

- ▶ ROUGE is a recall-focused metric widely used in text summarization to evaluate how much of the reference content is captured by the generated text.
- ▶ Common variants:
 - **ROUGE-N**: recall of n-grams.
 - **ROUGE-L**: based on the longest common subsequence.
- ▶ Formula (ROUGE-N):

$$\text{ROUGE-N} = \frac{\sum_{n\text{-gram} \in \text{Ref}} \min(\text{count}_{\text{hyp}}, \text{count}_{\text{ref}})}{\sum_{n\text{-gram} \in \text{Ref}} \text{count}_{\text{ref}}}$$

► Example:

- Reference: “the cat sat on the mat”
- Hypothesis: “the cat sat on mat”
- ROUGE-1 recall = $5/6 \approx 83\%$

► Why it matters:

- Good for checking content coverage in summarization tasks.

- ▶ **METEOR:** Measures text generation quality considering not just exact word matches but also stemming, synonyms, and paraphrases. Tends to correlate better with human judgment than BLEU.
- ▶ **TER (Translation Edit Rate):** Takes the minimum number of edits (insertions, deletions, substitutions, and shifts of word sequences) needed to match the reference, divided by the average reference length. Lower TER indicates better performance.
- ▶ Why these metrics matter:
 - Often used alongside BLEU and ROUGE to get a more complete evaluation of generated text quality.

- ▶ **Automated Metrics** (e.g., BLEU, ROUGE):
 - **Positive:** Cheap, fast, and reproducible.
 - **Negative:** Limited depth; may not capture fluency, naturalness, or true meaning.
- ▶ **Human Evaluation:**
 - **Positive:** Captures fluency, naturalness, and semantic meaning.
 - **Negative:** Expensive, slow, and less reproducible.
- ▶ **Why both matter:**
 - Automated metrics allow rapid iteration and benchmarking.
 - Human evaluation ensures quality aligns with real-world perception.
 - Best practice: combine both depending on the task.

- ▶ Reference: “The cat sat on the mat.”
- ▶ Hypotheses:
 - Hypothesis A: “The cat is on the mat.”
 - Hypothesis B: “A feline rested on the rug.”
- ▶ Metric evaluation:
 - **BLEU:** $A \not\sim B$ (closer word overlap with reference)
 - **ROUGE:** $A \not\sim B$ (better recall of reference n-grams)
 - Hypothesis B is semantically correct, yet both metrics punish it.
- ▶ Takeaway:
 - Different metrics capture different aspects of quality.
 - Word overlap metrics may disagree with human or semantic judgment.

- ▶ Still sequential, so **not fully parallelizable**
- ▶ Attention adds computational cost
- ▶ Hard to interpret in large-scale models
- ▶ Might struggle with very long-range dependencies in huge contexts

- ▶ **Transformers:** Fully attention-based, no recurrence
- ▶ **Efficient Attention Models:** Longformer, Reformer, Linformer
- ▶ **Multimodal Attention:** Vision + Text
- ▶ **Memory-Augmented Models**
- ▶ **Structured Attention:** Parses, syntax, and alignment bias

Attention underpins GPT, BERT, and today's LLMs

- ▶ Seq2Seq enables mapping input to output sequences of variable lengths
- ▶ **Bottleneck:** Fixed-size context vector limits learning capacity
- ▶ **Attention:** Improves performance by giving **adaptive access** to input states
- ▶ Attention → Transformer → LLMs
- ▶ Still evolving: From additive attention to self-attention and beyond

These slides have been adapted from:

- ▶ Younes Mourri & Lukasz Kaiser, [Natural Language Processing Specialization, DeepLearning.AI](#)
- ▶ Bhiksha Raj & Rita Singh, [11-785 Introduction to Deep Learning, CMU](#)

Diagrams credited to CMU 11-785 are adapted rather than reproduced verbatim: the context-vector notation has been corrected to match the definitions used here.

Foundational Papers:

- ▶ Sutskever et al. (2014). *Sequence to Sequence Learning with Neural Networks*. NeurIPS.
- ▶ Bahdanau et al. (2014). *Neural Machine Translation by Jointly Learning to Align and Translate*.
- ▶ Luong et al. (2015). *Effective Approaches to Attention-based Neural Machine Translation*.
- ▶ Vaswani et al. (2017). *Attention Is All You Need* (Transformer).
- ▶ Chan et al. (2016). *Listen, Attend and Spell* (Speech recognition).

Decoding and Evaluation:

- ▶ Wu et al. (2016). *Google's Neural Machine Translation System: Bridging the Gap between Human and Machine Translation*. arXiv:1609.08144.
- ▶ Papineni et al. (2002). *BLEU: a Method for Automatic Evaluation of Machine Translation*. ACL.
- ▶ Lin (2004). *ROUGE: A Package for Automatic Evaluation of Summaries*. ACL Workshop on Text Summarization Branches Out.
- ▶ Banerjee & Lavie (2005). *METEOR: An Automatic Metric for MT Evaluation with Improved Correlation with Human Judgments*. ACL Workshop on Intrinsic and Extrinsic Evaluation Measures for MT.
- ▶ Snover et al. (2006). *A Study of Translation Edit Rate with Targeted Human Annotation*. AMTA.

Courses & Tutorials:

- ▶ Stanford CS224n, *Lecture Notes Part VI: Neural Machine Translation, Seq2seq and Attention* (Winter 2019)
- ▶ DeepLearning.ai NLP Specialization (Coursera)
- ▶ Harvard NLP Annotated Transformer:
<http://nlp.seas.harvard.edu/2018/04/03/attention.html>
- ▶ Jay Alammam's blog: "The Illustrated Transformer"
- ▶ Andrej Karpathy (2015). "The Unreasonable Effectiveness of Recurrent Neural Networks":
<https://karpathy.github.io/2015/05/21/rnn-effectiveness/>